human form at this same time, dramatically coming into his own in a great surge of popular belief that had its beginnings in the Tamil South in the seventh century and spread northwards, replacing Brahminical Vedism with the popular Hinduism that so many millions follow today.

At its heart was the new concept of bhakti ('devotion or piety'), which turned its back on priest-led ritual to embrace personal devotion to a particular deity as the path to salvation. This enabled ordinary men and women to engage in their own ecstatic and even mystical relationship with their chosen deity without priestly intercession – the key word here being *bhagavata*, or 'devotee of the Lord (Bhagavan)', describing that close connection between deity and worshipper. As an aid to bhakti, the so-called agamic texts were introduced, derived from the Sanskrit *agama*, 'what has been handed down'. These were essentially devotional manuals of service that purported to be ancient but were newly written, their core texts being the eighteen *Mahapurana*s – 'the great ancient (writings)' – which prophesied events to come that had already taken place.[6] These played a key role in the propaganda battles for popular support waged between the two rival religious parties that is still being waged today.

This was nothing less than a Hindu revolution, which sidelined the old abstract Vedic deities in favour of younger and more interactive and accessible gods. The two clear winners were Vishnu, along with his ten avatars – extending from the axe-wielding warrior Parashurama to Krishna and Rama and even sometimes the Buddha as the ninth avatar – and Shiva in all his forms. The triumph of these two super-deities was made complete with the absorption of Shakti, the female element, so that the two opposite forces of male and female were joined in union – in the case of Lord Shiva *devis* ranging from Parvati to Durga by way of Sati, Chamunda and Kali, and in the case of Vishnu his *shakti*